

MC 501 RESEARCH PROPOSAL TEMPLATE

What you submit: one document of 1,200 to 1,800 words in outline form, with seven headed sections plus References. **75 points. Due Monday, October 12, 11:59 PM, in Blackboard.**

Use these section names, in this order, as the headings of your own document. Each section below says what it is worth, the question it answers, and what it has to contain. The checks and the weaker and stronger examples for every section are on the web page: <https://aura-lab.siue.edu/v2v-hub/mc501-research-proposal-template.html>.

Framing: 8 points

The question it answers: what is happening, among whom and where, and what goes wrong if we get the answer wrong?

Write: three to five points. **It has to contain four things:** the phenomenon, the population (platform, accounts or outlets, and period), why it matters now, and what is at stake in getting the answer wrong.

Theoretical positioning: 15 points

The question it answers: which lens predicts what you will see and why, and what would a rival lens predict instead?

Write: four to six points. **It has to contain five things:** the lens, what it predicts you will see, why it predicts that, a competing lens with what it predicts instead, and how your design can tell the two apart. The competing lens is required; a framework with no rival is a decoration.

The literature: 15 points

The question it answers: where do the studies agree, where do they differ, and what do they all leave out?

Write: six to ten points, organized by theme rather than by author. **It has to contain three things:** where the studies agree, where they differ or qualify each other, and the limitation they share, each with its citations. This is your synthesis paragraph from Annotated Manuscripts, expanded.

The gap: 8 points

The question it answers: what does that shared limitation leave unanswered?

Write: two to three points. **It has to contain three things:** the shared limitation from the literature section, the closest studies it applies to, and the question it leaves open, which is the one your study asks.

Research questions or hypotheses: 10 points

The question it answers: what will you find out, and which theory point does each one come from?

Write: your research questions and hypotheses, stated formally. **Each one has to contain:** the question or the predicted relationship, and the theory point it comes from. These are your Topic Selection questions, revised by your feedback.

The proposed design: 15 points

The question it answers: what will you code, from where, how, how consistently, and with what analysis, all decided before you see the data?

Write: eight to twelve points. **It has to contain six things:** the unit of analysis, the population and frame, the sampling method, the measurement of each variable, the reliability protocol you intend, and the analysis you plan before you see the data. Fewer than eight points usually means one of the six is missing or a variable has no measurement.

Contribution: 4 points

The question it answers: what will researchers in your field know afterward that they do not know now?

Write: two to three points, written for your field rather than for this course. **It has to contain two things:** who in your field learns something, and what they learn that your data can actually show.

References

Required: APA 7 for every source cited in the outline, and only sources you cited.